Steam Review Diagnostics by Playtime Stage

Apex Legends, Icarus and Path of Exile | Frozen review snapshots

Question: How do recommendation rates and theme mentions differ between reviewers with different amounts of cumulative playtime?

My contribution: review analysis, Python aggregation, dashboard interpretation and documented product hypotheses. The revised report reconciles its counts and rates to the same frozen review cohort for each game.

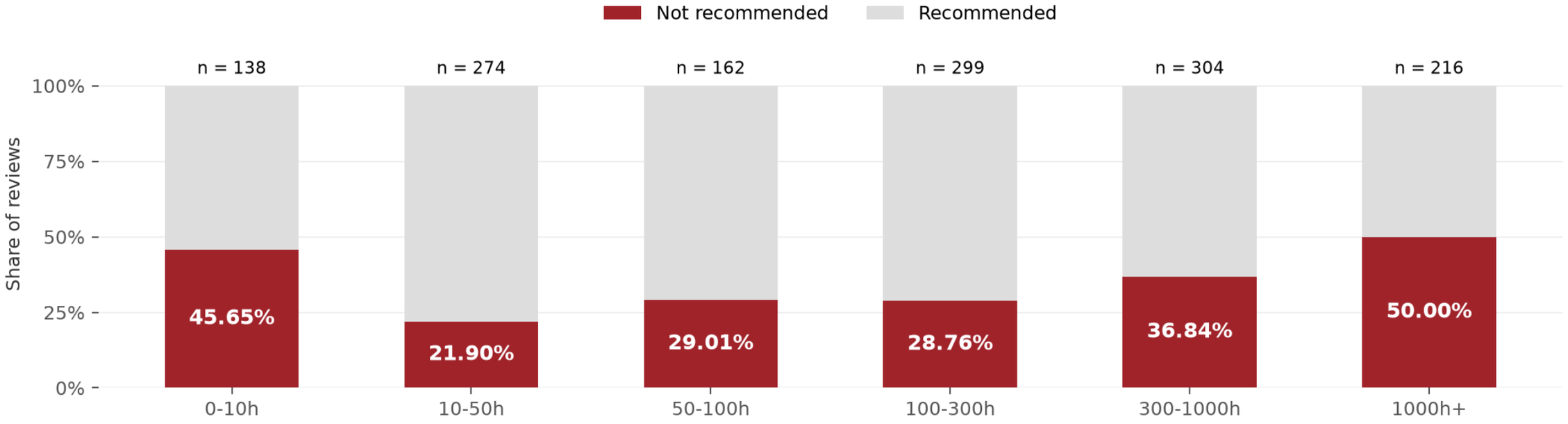
Game	All reviews	Negative reviews	Positive reviews with 50h+
Apex Legends	1,393	476	628
Icarus	1,445	288	899
Path of Exile	1,496	256	1,081

Measure: Steam recommendation label. Negative rate = negative reviews / all reviews in the same game and playtime group. Playtime means cumulative hours at collection, not hours when the review was posted.

Interpretation: These are comparisons between self-selected reviewers. They do not measure retention, churn, conversion or how individual players change over time. Theme matches identify mentions, not the sentiment of each feature.

Apex Legends: recommendation rates

Cumulative playtime at collection | Each bar shows its own sample size



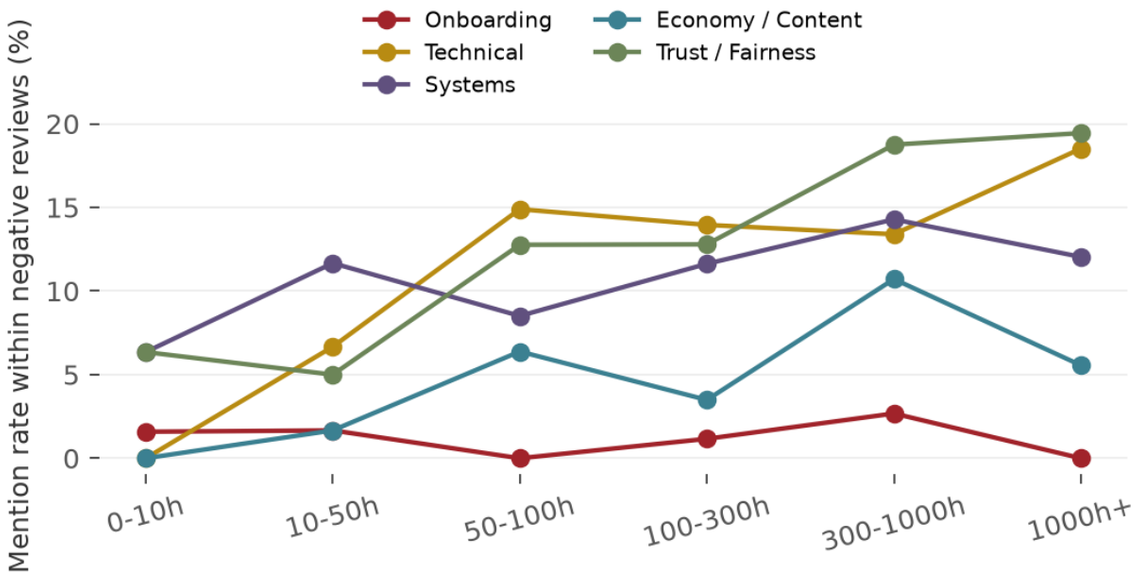
What the sample shows

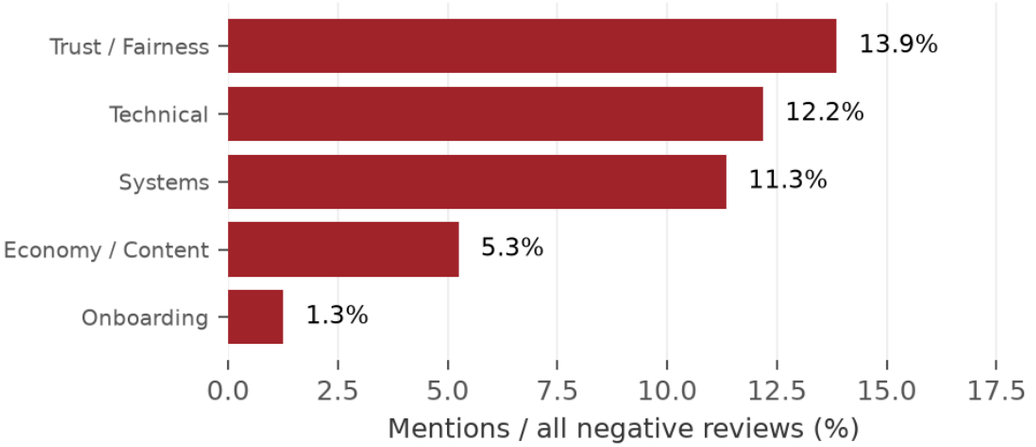
The 0-10h group has 63 negative reviews out of 138 (45.65%). The lowest negative rate is 21.90% at 10-50h; the 1000h+ group is 50.00%. This motivates investigating concerns voiced by highly experienced reviewers, without attributing the difference to time spent playing.

Groups use lower-inclusive, upper-exclusive boundaries: exactly 50h belongs to 50-100h. Small groups should be read cautiously.

Apex Legends: themes in negative reviews

Explicit dictionary v2 | A review can mention several themes





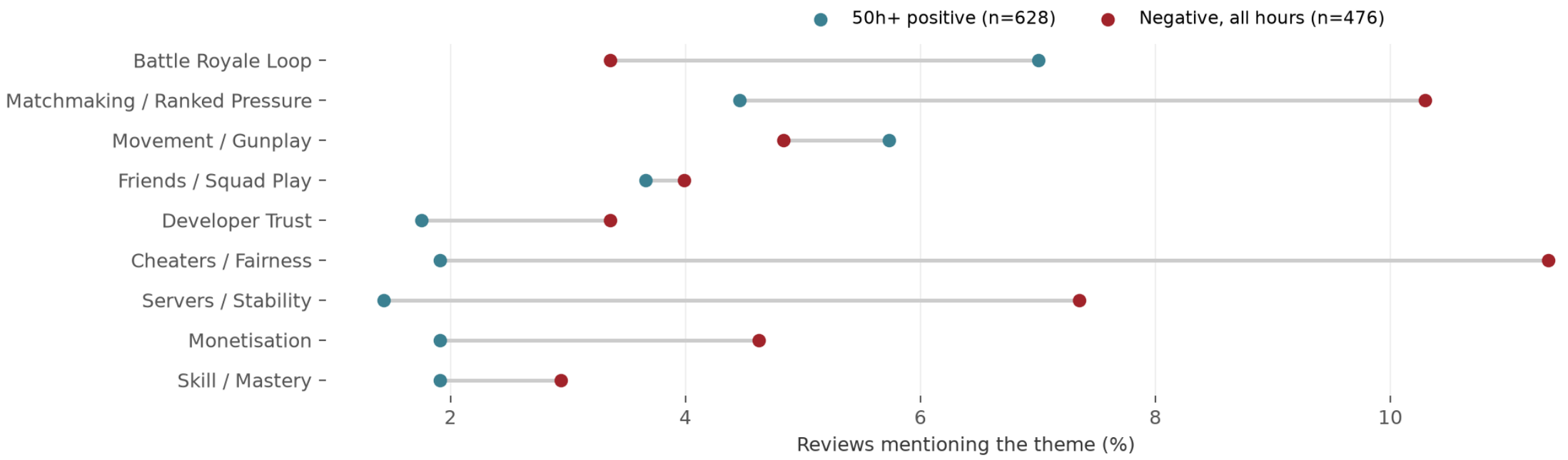
What the sample shows

The most frequently matched theme is **Trust / Fairness**: 66 of 476 negative reviews (13.87%). The overall chart weights by review count; it is not an unweighted mean of the six stage percentages.

Negative-review denominators, left to right: 63, 60, 47, 86, 112, 108. A stage peak based on few reviews is exploratory. Keyword matches can include praise, negation or sarcasm.

Apex Legends: positive and negative review language

50h+ positive reviews compared with negative reviews at all playtimes



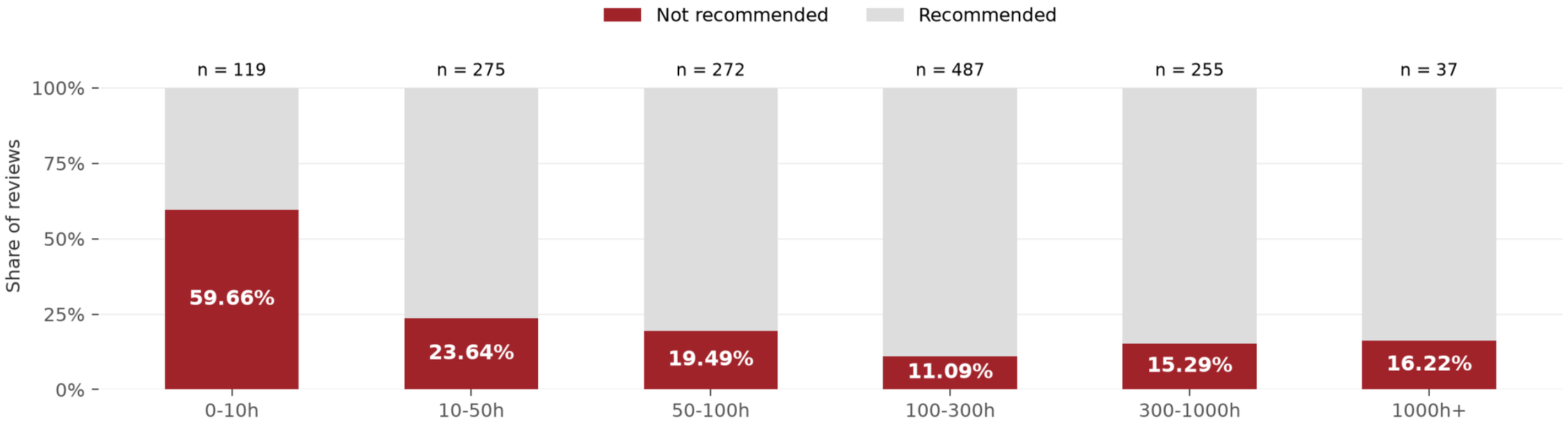
What the sample shows

Cheaters / Fairness is mentioned in 11.34% of negative reviews and 1.91% of 50h+ positive reviews. This is a useful topic for follow-up reading, not a measured cause of dissatisfaction.

The two groups differ in both recommendation label and playtime eligibility. '50h+ positive' is a descriptive subset, not evidence that a player stayed active or stayed positive over time.

Icarus: recommendation rates

Cumulative playtime at collection | Each bar shows its own sample size



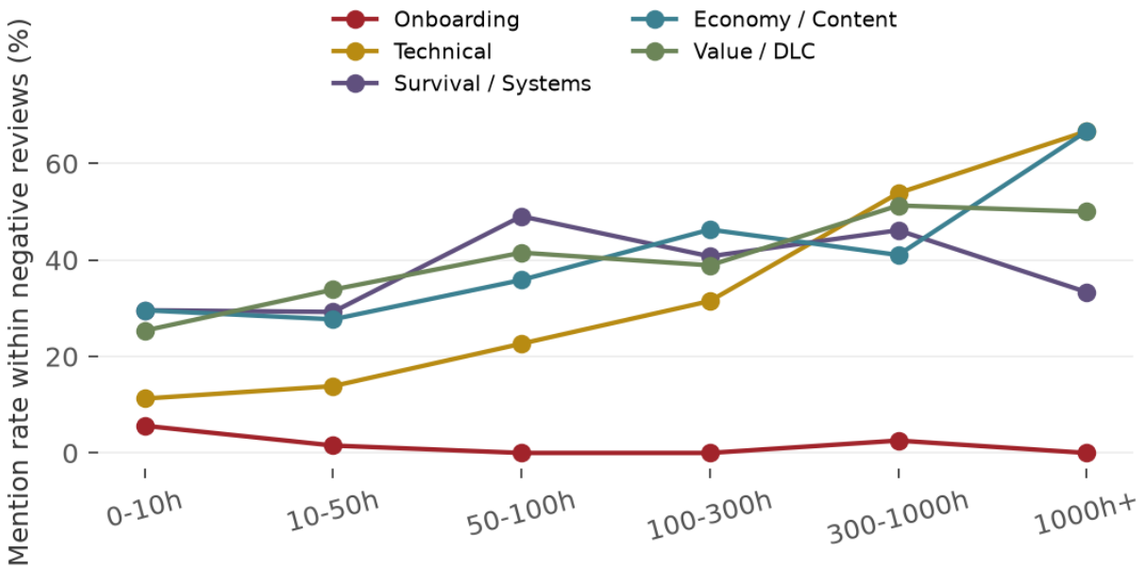
What the sample shows

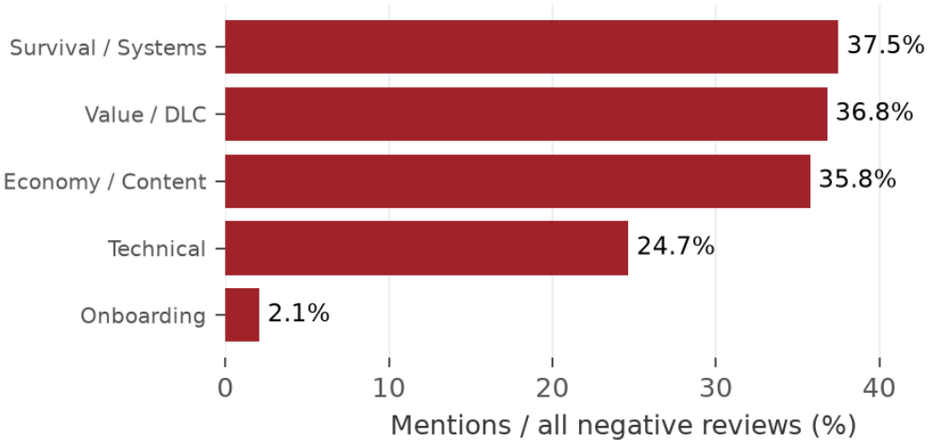
The highest negative rate is 59.66% in the 0-10h group (71/119). Groups above 50h range from 11.09% to 19.49%. These differences support investigating first-session expectations and perceived value; they do not show that players left the game.

Groups use lower-inclusive, upper-exclusive boundaries: exactly 50h belongs to 50-100h. Small groups should be read cautiously.

Icarus: themes in negative reviews

Explicit dictionary v2 | A review can mention several themes





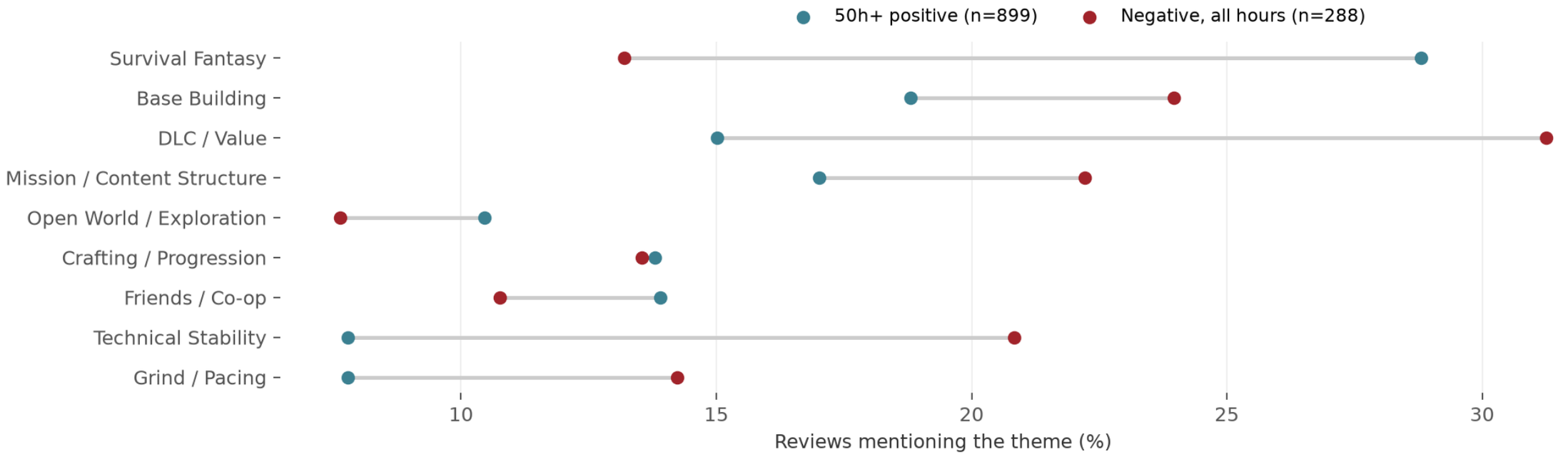
What the sample shows

The most frequently matched theme is **Survival / Systems**: 108 of 288 negative reviews (37.50%). The overall chart weights by review count; it is not an unweighted mean of the six stage percentages.

Negative-review denominators, left to right: 71, 65, 53, 54, 39, 6. A stage peak based on few reviews is exploratory. Keyword matches can include praise, negation or sarcasm.

Icarus: positive and negative review language

50h+ positive reviews compared with negative reviews at all playtimes



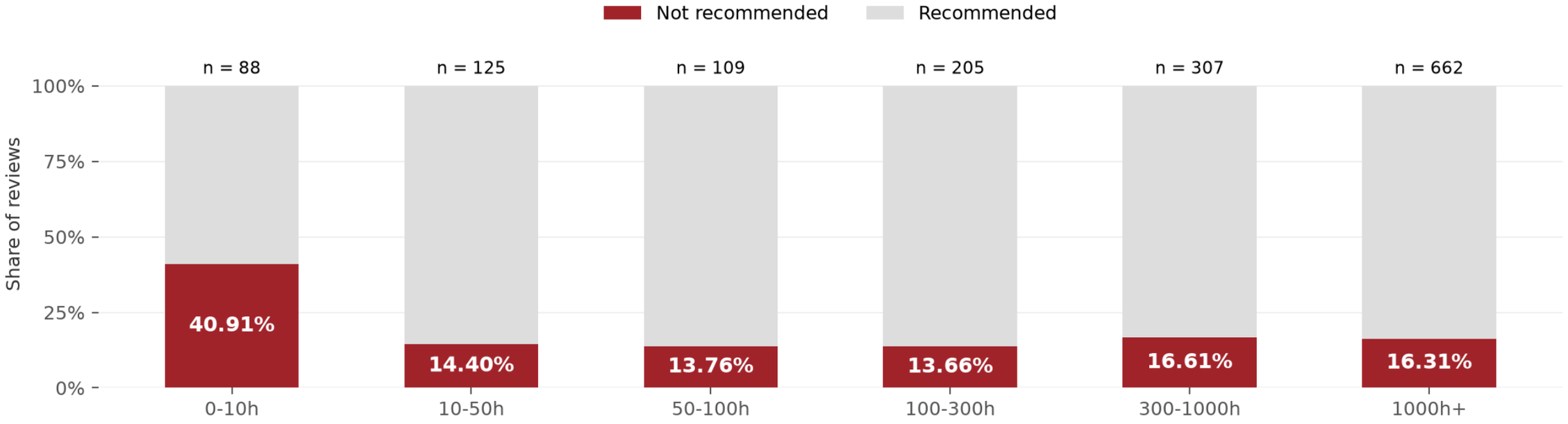
What the sample shows

DLC / Value is mentioned in 31.25% of negative reviews and 15.02% of 50h+ positive reviews. This is a useful topic for follow-up reading, not a measured cause of dissatisfaction.

The two groups differ in both recommendation label and playtime eligibility. '50h+ positive' is a descriptive subset, not evidence that a player stayed active or stayed positive over time.

Path of Exile: recommendation rates

Cumulative playtime at collection | Each bar shows its own sample size



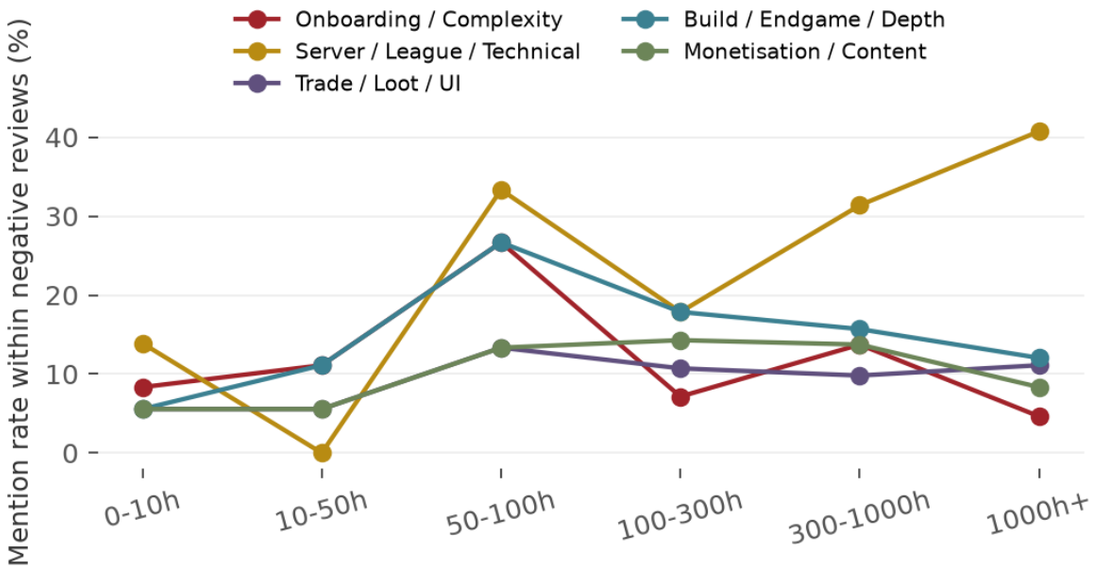
What the sample shows

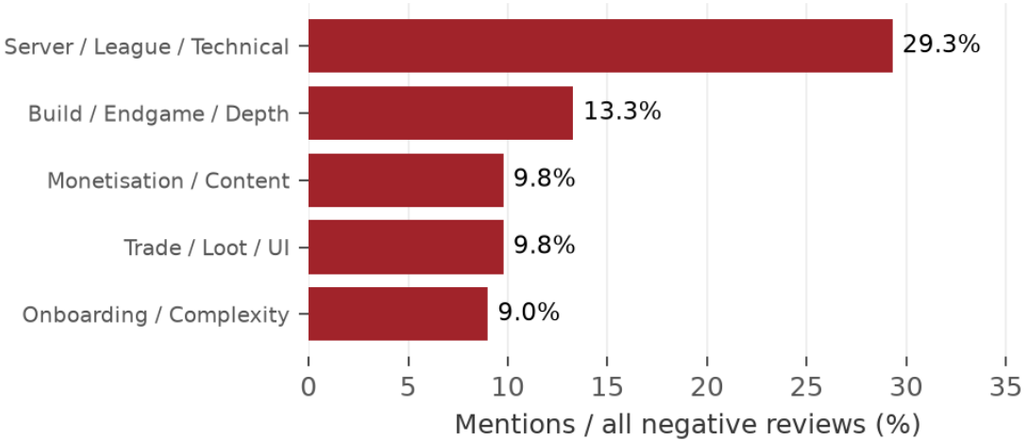
The 0-10h group has a 40.91% negative rate (36/88). Later groups range from 13.66% to 16.61%. This supports exploring access to complex systems as a research question; the review sample cannot establish when a complaint first emerged.

Groups use lower-inclusive, upper-exclusive boundaries: exactly 50h belongs to 50-100h. Small groups should be read cautiously.

Path of Exile: themes in negative reviews

Explicit dictionary v2 | A review can mention several themes





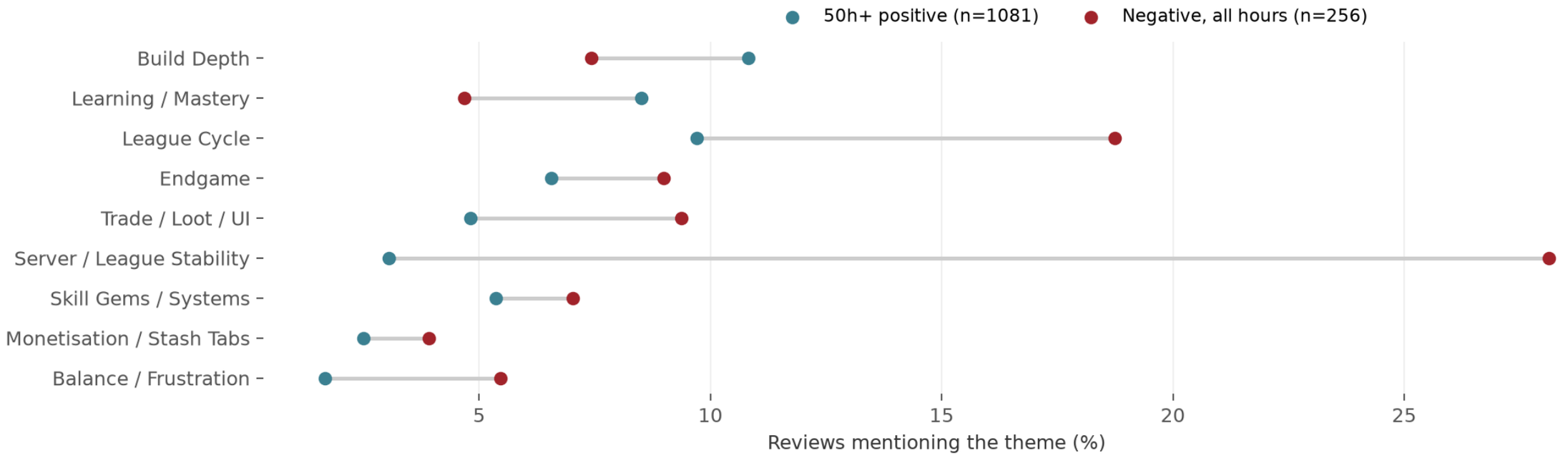
What the sample shows

The most frequently matched theme is **Server / League / Technical**: 75 of 256 negative reviews (29.30%). The overall chart weights by review count; it is not an unweighted mean of the six stage percentages.

Negative-review denominators, left to right: 36, 18, 15, 28, 51, 108. A stage peak based on few reviews is exploratory. Keyword matches can include praise, negation or sarcasm.

Path of Exile: positive and negative review language

50h+ positive reviews compared with negative reviews at all playtimes



What the sample shows

Server / League Stability is mentioned in 28.12% of negative reviews and 3.05% of 50h+ positive reviews. This is a useful topic for follow-up reading, not a measured cause of dissatisfaction.

The two groups differ in both recommendation label and playtime eligibility. '50h+ positive' is a descriptive subset, not evidence that a player stayed active or stayed positive over time.

Findings and next questions

Observed differences first; product and marketing ideas require testing

Game	0-10h	10-50h	50-100h	100-300h	300-1000h	1000h+
Apex Legends	45.65%	21.90%	29.01%	28.76%	36.84%	50.00%
Icarus	59.66%	23.64%	19.49%	11.09%	15.29%	16.22%
Path of Exile	40.91%	14.40%	13.76%	13.66%	16.61%	16.31%

Apex Legends: investigate fairness, technical reliability and ranked-system expectations in experienced reviewers. The sample shows differing recommendation rates; it does not establish trust erosion in the same people over time.

Icarus: investigate how early-session guidance and price/DLC expectations relate to expressed dissatisfaction. Test clearer product messaging or onboarding with new users before claiming an effect.

Path of Exile: investigate technical access and explanations of complex systems. A guide or creator-led introduction is a testable marketing/content hypothesis, not a validated conversion lever.

Limits: historical English-review snapshots, self-selection and keyword rules. The report contains no retention telemetry, causal experiment or campaign outcome. Rebuild inputs and hashes are recorded in data/case1_provenance.json; method and revisions are documented in docs/case1-method.md.